

Parent Guide — middle / module-01- what-is-iks

IKS Curriculum

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Parent Guide — Module 1: What is IKS?

Your child's age: Middle (Grades 6–8) · **Module length:** 10 sessions × 45 min

What your child is learning

The map of Indian Knowledge Systems — what's actually in there, beyond yoga and curry:

- **Vedas** — the oldest layer; ritual hymns + early linguistic and astronomical observation.
- **Vedangas** — six auxiliary disciplines (phonetics, ritual, grammar, etymology, prosody, astronomy).
- **Upavedas** — four applied sciences: **Ayurveda** (medicine), **Dhanurveda** (martial arts), **Gandharvaveda** (music), **Arthaśāstra** (governance/economics).
- Specific Indian contributions: **zero**, decimal place-value, infinite series (Mādhava, 14th c.), planetary calculations (Sūrya-siddhānta), Sushruta's surgical procedures (~6th c. BCE), Pāṇini's formal grammar (~4th c. BCE).

What this module is — and isn't

Is: An honest, specific introduction to the *intellectual traditions* developed on the Indian subcontinent. With dates, names, and primary-source references.

Isn't: Religious instruction. Nor a competition with modern science. Nor uncritical promotion of “everything Indian came first.”

The framing we model: - Real achievements, specifically named, with what they got right AND what they got wrong. - Tradition presented as historical context for ongoing inquiry. - Modern science included as a partner, not a rival.

Project (Days 8–10)

Your child picks ONE strand (math, astronomy, medicine, music, architecture, etc.) and gives a 5-minute presentation. Required: - A named practitioner (Aryabhata, Sushruta, Pāṇini, etc.). - One primary or scholarly source citation. - A fair statement of what the tradition does AND does not claim.

How to help

Helpful: - Ask your child to teach you ONE strand. The act of teaching cements the learning. - Pull a relevant book from your shelf if you have one — *Mathematics in India* (Plofker), *The Roots of Ayurveda* (Wujastyk), *Light on Yoga* (Iyengar). - For the project: be a thoughtful skeptic. Ask “where is the evidence for that?”

Not helpful: - Saying “ancient Indians invented everything.” This isn’t what we teach. - Saying “all that is just myth.” This also isn’t what we teach. - Doing the project. The research IS the learning.

What success looks like

- Your child can list the four Vedas, the six Vedangas, and the four Upavedas with one-line descriptions.
- They can name at least one specific Indian contribution in each of: mathematics, astronomy, medicine.
- They can articulate what IKS includes and what it doesn’t.
- They give a confident 5-minute presentation with citations.

Want to go deeper?

Recommended for further reading: - Plofker, K. (2009). *Mathematics in India*. Princeton. - Wujastyk, D. (2003). *The Roots of Ayurveda*. Penguin. - Bryant, E. F. (2009). *The Yoga Sūtras of Patañjali*. North Point.

10-Day Lesson Plan

Module 1 (Middle) — 10-Day Lesson Plan

At a glance

Day	Session	File	Activity
1	Hook — what is IKS?	days/day-01-hook.md	Open discussion
2	The Four Vedas	days/day-02-vedas.md	Tree-building
3	The Six Vedangas	days/day-03-vedangas.md	Matching game
4	The Four Upavedas	days/day-04-upavedas.md	Application examples
5	Mid-module check	days/day-05-mid-module.md	Formative quiz
6	Indian Mathematics	days/day-06-	Zero & decimal demo

Day	Session	File	Activity
		mathematics. md	
7	Indian Astronomy	days/day-07- astronomy.md	Aryabhata reading
8	Project Session 1	days/day-08- project- session-1.md	Research + outline
9	Project Session 2	days/day-09- project- session-2.md	Rehearsal
10	Final presentations	days/day-10- final- assessment.m d	5-min talks

Pacing

- Days 1–4 are survey-heavy. Don’t go deep — give the map.
- Days 6–7 zoom in on math & astronomy specifically (depth on demand).
- Day 10 needs ~6 min per student (5 talk + 1 Q&A). 12+ students = book a second period.

Daily warm-up

Open with the question: “*What’s one Indian-origin idea you encountered yesterday outside this class?*” (Yoga, zero in math homework, an Ayurvedic ingredient in family cooking, an Indian-named star, etc.) Two students share.

What students leave with

- A vocabulary for talking about IKS as *intellectual traditions* (not religion alone).
- The tree of Vedas → Vedangas → Upavedas as a mental map.
- Specific named achievements (zero, Aryabhata’s earth’s rotation, Sushruta’s surgery) with dates.
- One well-researched 5-minute presentation.

Homework

Homework — Module 1 (Middle)

Day	Task	Time
1 → 2	Read the project brief. Think about which strand interests you.	15 min
2 → 3	Find one Upaniṣad name (look	10 min

Day	Task	Time
	up the list of 13 principal ones).	
3 → 4	Look up one Sanskrit etymology online. Bring an example.	10 min
4 → 5	Look up “Kauṭilya’s Arthaśāstra” — find one specific governance idea.	15 min
5 → 6	Submit project plan (working title + thesis sentence + 2 sources).	30 min
6 → 7	Compute 10 terms of the Mādhava π series.	15 min
7 → 8	Finalise topic; gather research materials.	30 min
8 → 9	Continue drafting at home (do NOT start tomorrow’s class without progress).	30–45 min
9 → 10	Final touches. Practise once aloud.	15 min